

Paul's Thorn in the Flesh

By David Michael Curtis

Dear friends,

Do you like a good mystery? Study the following verses and see if you can figure out what Paul's thorn in the flesh is and what his infirmity was. I'll give you a little backstory of Paul's life to help you figure it out.

1. Paul never married (1 Corinthians 7).
2. The law that Paul died to (Romans 7:1-5) had the commandment, "**Thou Shalt Not Covet**" Romans 7:7. This commandment taught Paul he had lust.

A good detective usually only has a few clues to solve the case. Whatever his "infirmity," he lived with it until his death and was not condemned by Romans 8:1. At the second coming, Paul will be delivered from it.

Paul's Infirmity

Galatians 4:13 Ye know how through **infirmity of the flesh** I preached the gospel unto you at the first.

2 Corinthians 11:30 If I must needs glory, I will glory of the things which concern **mine infirmities**.

2 Corinthians 12:5 Of such an one will I glory: yet of myself I will not glory, but in **mine infirmities**.

2 Corinthians 12:9-10 And he said unto me, My grace is sufficient for thee: for my strength is made perfect in weakness. Most gladly therefore will I rather glory **in my infirmities**, that the power of Christ may rest upon me. 10 Therefore I take pleasure **in infirmities**, in reproaches, in necessities, in persecutions, in distresses for Christ's sake: for when I am weak, then am I strong.

Romans 6:19 I speak after the manner of men because of the **infirmity of your flesh**: for as ye have yielded your members servants to uncleanness and to iniquity unto iniquity; even so now yield your members servants to righteousness unto holiness.

What was Paul's Infirmary?

Romans 7:14 For we know that the law is spiritual: but **I am carnal, sold under sin**. 15 For that which I do I allow not: for what I would, that do I not; but **what I hate, that do I**. 16 If then I do that which I would not, I consent unto the law that *it is* good. 17 Now then it is no more I that do it, but **sin that dwelleth in me**. 18 For I know that in me (that is, **in my flesh,**) **dwelleth no good thing**: for to will is present with me; but **how to perform that which is good I find not**. 19 For the good that I would I do not: but **the evil which I would not, that I do**. 20 Now if **I do that I would not**, it is no more I that do it, but **sin that dwelleth in me**. 21 I find then a law, that, when I would do good, **evil is present with me**. 22 For I delight in the law of God after the inward man: 23 But I see **another law in my members**, warring against the law of my mind, and bringing me into captivity to **the law of sin which is in my members**. 24 O wretched man that I am! who shall deliver me from the **body of this death**? 25 I thank God through Jesus Christ our Lord. So then with the mind **I myself serve** the law of God; but with **the flesh the law of sin**.

Gentile Nations Were a Thorn

Numbers 33:55 But if ye will not drive out the inhabitants of the land from before you; then it shall come to pass, that those which ye let remain of them shall be pricks in your eyes, and **thorns in your sides**, and shall vex you in the land wherein ye dwell.

Joshua 23:13 Know for a certainty that the LORD your God will no more drive out any of these nations from before you; but they shall be snares and traps unto you, and scourges in your sides, and **thorns in your eyes**, until ye perish from off this good land which the LORD your God hath given you.

Judges 2:1-3 And an angel of the LORD came up from Gilgal to Bochim, and said, I made you to go up out of Egypt, and have brought you unto the land which I swore unto your Fathers; and I said, I will never break my covenant with you. And ye shall make no league with the inhabitants of this land; ye shall throw down their Altars: but ye have not obeyed my voice: why have ye done this? Wherefore I also said, I will not drive them out from before you; but **they shall be as thorns in your sides**, and their gods shall be a snare unto you.

Ezekiel 28:24 And there shall be no more a pricking brier unto the house of Israel, **nor any grieving thorn of all that are round about them**, that despised them; and they shall know that I am the Lord GOD.